



“The swept wings gave an impression of arrow swiftness; the shining body, of brightness and cleanness; the eight great engines, of power and pure functional efficiency... [In the bomb bay] were stored two thermonuclear bombs.”

PETER GEORGE

DR. STRANGELOVE OR: HOW I LEARNED TO STOP WORRYING AND LOVE THE BOMB

LOCKHEED U-2R

The Lockheed U-2 high-altitude reconnaissance aircraft was used as a spyplane to overfly the USSR during the Cold War. Its altitude was supposed to put the U-2 out of reach of Soviet interceptors and missiles, but two were shot down in the 1960s.

COLD WAR WARRIORS

IN THE DECADES AFTER THE END OF WORLD WAR II, NUCLEAR-ARMED AIR FORCES TRAINED TIRELESSLY TO FIGHT A THIRD WORLD WAR THAT NEVER CAME

AT THE HEIGHT OF THE COLD WAR, on any day or night, about 600 American nuclear-armed bombers stood fully fueled on alert, dispersed at airbases across the United States and in allied countries. Near the bombers their crews waited, studying weather briefings and mission plans, playing cards or watching movies, theoretically prepared at any moment for the call to be airborne in 15 minutes, before their bases could be vaporized by a Soviet surprise attack. For extra insurance, between a dozen and 70 nuclear bombers were on permanent airborne alert over the Atlantic, flying exhausting 24-hour shifts that covered 10,000 miles (16,000km), ready and waiting to be directed toward the Soviet Union. If the call came, the B-52s or B-47s would go in low, ducking under Soviet radar, shuddering and bucking over the ground contours to deliver their weapons of mass destruction. This was the world of Dr. Strangelove and of Mutually Assured Destruction — in which the only rational

way to keep the peace was to maintain the real threat of instant annihilation. And airmen were the intended agents of this Armageddon.

The dropping of the atom bombs on Hiroshima and Nagasaki in 1945 had opened a new era in aerial warfare. By the 1950s, both sides in the Cold

